

China Moves to Punish Bribe-Givers as Well as Corrupt Officials

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China said it will intensify efforts to punish those who offer bribes, alongside officials who accept them, signaling a broader anti-corruption push aimed at both sides of illicit transactions.

In a work report released after a key meeting earlier this year, the Communist Party of China Central Commission for Discipline Inspection said enforcement will increasingly focus on cases involving repeated bribery, large sums of money and efforts to influence multiple officials. The country's top anti-corruption body also plan to establish a nationwide registry of bribers and strengthen cross-agency sanctions through revisions to relevant laws.

The move marks a shift from previous campaigns that primarily targeted corrupt officials, extending accountability to businesses and individuals that seek improper benefits through bribery, analysts said.

Recent court rulings illustrate the approach.

In southwest China's Yunnan province, a construction company executive was sentenced to prison after authorities found he had paid bribes over a decade to secure project approvals and contracts. Courts also handed lengthy prison terms to several senior local officials who accepted the payments. The company involved was fined, while illegal gains were confiscated, according to judicial documents.

Court documents said some bribery took place openly in government offices over long periods, reflecting entrenched collusion between business interests and local officials in sectors such as construction and infrastructure.

A similar case emerged in southern China's Hainan province, where courts convicted multiple business figures for bribing senior public security officials to obtain protection for illegal activities, including unauthorized sand dredging. The officials involved were dismissed and transferred to judicial authorities, while the bribers received prison sentences of up to two decades, according to official statements.

The cases highlight how bribery has been used to penetrate local governance and law enforcement, particularly in areas involving public resources and project approvals, analysts said.

China has been tightening its legal framework to address such practices. A draft revision to the criminal law released last year would complement the enforcement push outlined in a recent work report, proposing harsher penalties for repeat bribery and for bribing multiple officials, and expanding the scope of criminal liability for those offering bribes.

The anti-corruption watchdog has said the changes are intended to curb systemic corruption by cutting off the incentives and channels that enable power-for-money deals, as enforcement increasingly targets both sides of the transaction.

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